

5.4 The Subtext Injection Technique

5.4.1 Choosing Your Felt and Expressed Emotions

Character: [CHARACTER_NAME]

Scene context: [BRIEF_DESCRIPTION_OF_WHAT_IS_HAPPENING]

Question	Your Answer
What is this character feeling underneath? (Draw from Layer Five: Core Wounds, or the scene's trigger)	[E.G., "Terrified of being abandoned"]
What is this character showing on the surface? (Draw from Layer Six: Aspirational Self-Image, or the default management strategy)	[E.G., "Irritated efficiency"]
What is the direction of the gap? (One step removed / one step brighter / one step darker)	[E.G., "One step removed: fear expressed as irritation"]
What are two specific delivery markers that make the felt emotion audible?	[E.G., "Sentences arrive one beat late. Vocabulary narrows to monosyllables."]

5.4.2 AI Prompt Template: Subtext Injection Instruction

Add this instruction to your prompt after your Dialogue Matrix and Three-Tier Emotional Filter. All four parts must be present for the subtext to land.

Copy the template below and fill in every bracket before adding it to your prompt.

In this scene, [CHARACTER_NAME] is feeling [FELT_EMOTION] but expressing [EXPRESSED_EMOTION]. The dialogue must show the gap between the two. The expressed emotion governs the words. The felt emotion governs the rhythm, the pacing, the word selection, and the conversational behavior. The reader should be able to identify the felt emotion without it being stated.

5.4.3 Case Application: Callum and Mara in the Same Scene

Use these worked examples to calibrate your own Subtext Injection instructions. Both characters feel terror in this scene, but their subtext sounds completely different because their management strategies run in opposite directions.

Callum's Subtext Injection (vulnerability scene):

"Callum is feeling terrified of being abandoned but expressing irritated efficiency. The dialogue must show the gap. The expressed irritation governs the words: short, blunt, directive. The felt terror governs the rhythm: the sentences arrive one beat late, the vocabulary narrows to monosyllables, the character changes subject before the other speaker can respond to the emotional content. The reader should be able to identify the terror without it being stated."

Mara's Subtext Injection (same scene):

"Mara is feeling terrified of being too much but expressing breezy reassurance. The dialogue must show the gap. The expressed reassurance governs the words: warm, effusive, intensifier-heavy. The felt terror governs the pacing: the sentences accelerate, the character asks a question before the previous sentence has landed, the laughter arrives half a beat too early. The reader should be able to identify the terror without it being stated."

Key Insight: Callum's terror slows the speech down and compresses it. Mara's terror speeds the speech up and inflates it. Same emotion, opposite management strategies, both audible to the reader.

5.4.4 Decision Tree: Diagnosing a Closed Gap

Use this tree when the spoken and the meant are aligned in your output (no subtext audible).

Step 1 – Read the generated dialogue aloud. Can you hear two layers?

- **Yes** → The subtext is audible. The gap is open. Move forward.
- **No** → Proceed to Step 2.

Step 2 – Which layer is missing?

Symptom	Diagnosis	Fix
Words sound correct for the expressed emotion, but delivery is flat (no rhythmic marker, no pacing shift)	Felt-emotion instruction lacks a delivery marker	Add one specific rhythmic or behavioral detail: the exact delay, acceleration, or word that arrives too late

Symptom	Diagnosis	Fix
Words sound like the felt emotion (character is saying what they feel)	Expressed-emotion instruction is too weak	Strengthen the mask: name the specific vocabulary, tone, and conversational behavior that covers the feeling
Both layers present but gap too subtle to notice	Insufficient markers	Add a second delivery marker; two markers make the divergence unmistakable

Step 3 – Adjust and regenerate. Insert a single marker. Regenerate the scene. Listen for the shift. Keep each cycle to one adjustment and one test.

5.4.5 Subtext Audibility Verification Checklist

Read the generated dialogue aloud and check each box.

- ☐ I can name the expressed emotion based on the words alone.
- ☐ I can name the felt emotion based on the rhythm, pacing, and delivery alone.
- ☐ The two emotions are different. The gap is open.
- ☐ The felt emotion is never stated directly in the dialogue. The reader infers it from the delivery.
- ☐ I can point to at least one specific word, pause, or rhythmic shift that signals the felt emotion underneath.
- ☐ If I read the dialogue to someone who knows the character, they would say, "I can tell they are feeling [FELT_EMOTION] even though they are saying [EXPRESSED_CONTENT]."

All six boxes checked means the subtext is alive and the gap is open.